Commercial Break and Midnight

By Tim Seibles

(Singing)
If you're on a highway and Road Runner goes beep beep.
Just step aside or you might end up in a heap.
Road Runner, Road Runner runs down the road all day.
Even the coyote can't make him change his ways.

Road Runner, the coyote's after you.
Road Runner, if he catches you you're through.

That coyote is really a crazy clown,
When will he learn that he never can mow him down?
Poor little Road Runner never bothers anyone,
Just runnin' down the road's his idea of having fun.

Lyrics and Music can be found at:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XuemcUasZ5E

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Barbara Cameron
ASIN: B0076XDT08
Publisher: BSX Records
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INTRODUCTION

Do you remember the old Saturday morning cartoon? The Road Runner Show! The one where there was no dialogue and the only line ever uttered was "Meep-Meep!" And yet we were mesmerized by the entire premise of the cartoon. We knew Wile E Coyote would never catch and eat the Road Runner, but watching his wide variety of failures was something we eagerly awaited every weekend. Tim Seibles explores the inner thoughts of both the Road Runner and the Coyote in these poems: Commercial Break and Midnight.

Commercial Break: Road-Runner, Uneasy

If I didn't know better I'd say
the sun never moved ever,

that somebody just pasted it there
and said the hell with it,

but that's impossible.
After a while you have to give up

those conspiracy theories.
I get the big picture. I mean,

how big can the picture be?
I actually think it's kind of funny —

that damn coyote always scheming,
always licking his skinny chops

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and me, pure speed, the object of all
his hunger, the *everything* he needs —

talk about **impossible**, talk about
the grass is always greener...

I **am** the other side of the fence.

You've got to wonder, at least a little,
if this could be a set-up:

with all the running I do —
the desert, the canyons, the hillsides, the desert —

all this open road has got to
lead somewhere else. I mean,

that's what freedom's all about, right?
Ending up where you want to be.

I used to think it was funny — *Roadrunner*
the coyote's after you Roadrunner...

Now I'm mainly tired. Not that
you'd ever know. I mean

I can still make the horizon
in two shakes of a snake's tongue,

but it never gets easier out here, alone
with Mr. Big Teeth and his ACME supplies:

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leg muscle vitamins, tiger traps,
instant tornado seeds.

C'mon! I'm no tiger.
And who's making all this stuff?

I can't help being a little uneasy.
I do one of my tricks,

a rock-scorching, razor turn at 600 miles an hour,
and he falls off the cliff, the coyote —

he really falls: I see the small explosion,
his body slamming into dry dirt

so far down in the canyon
the river looks like a crayon doodle.

That has to hurt, right?
Five seconds later, he's just up the highway

hoisting a huge anvil
above a little, yellow dish of bird feed —

like I don't see what's goin' on. C'mon!

You know how sometimes, even though you're
very serious about the things you do,

it seems like, secretly, there's a
big joke being played,

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and you're part of what
someone else is laughing at — only

you can't prove it, so you
keep sweating and believing in

your *career*, as if that
makes the difference, as if somehow

playing along isn't really

playing along as long as you're
not sure what sort of fool

you're being turned into, especially
if you're giving it *one-hundred percent*.

So, when I see dynamite
tucked under the ACME road-runner cupcakes,

as long as I don't wonder why my safety
isn't coming first in this situation,

as long as I don't think me
and the coyote are actually

working for the same people,

as long as I eat and
get away I'm not really stupid,

right? I'm just fast.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tim Seibles
Book: Hammerlock
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Publisher: Cleveland State U Poetry Center
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1999

TRANSITION

Over the years, poor Wile E. Coyote suffered a lot of heartache and physical pain in his quest for sustenance. It almost seemed like he'd been cursed, and he was, in fact — by none other than animator Chuck Jones. Wile E. Coyote, genius. Who else would think of such elaborate schemes to get a meal? Does it matter that all of his schemes failed? It may have left him perpetually hungry, but it doesn't change his status as one of the most creative and undaunted coyotes around. Midnight by Tim Seibles

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Midnight: The Coyote, Down in the Mouth

I used to sleep so well.
My mother could carry me
by the neck scruff without waking me up.

Even the dark tasted good
with the quite noise of family around me,

and sunrise simply meant I could catch
grasshoppers drunk on due.

Of course I didn't know the roadrunner then
and whatever I wanted seemed nearby and easy.

Now, I close my eyes and he's there
in slow motion technicolor
all a-trot. His heart like a little tom-tom
loud enough to be visible in that bony chest.

Come morning, it will be the same, but hotter.
A buzz of shins, the road sizzling like a fuse.
Meep. . . . Meep . . .

I used to believe what I did mattered in
some spectacular way

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As if a big audience sat somewhere
really watching
really wondering
how well I would do out here.

At first I thought it was only a matter of time.
I'd put on a bib,
pick up some silverware,
duck behind a cactus,
just to ham it up a little.

He was mine.

I figured a few near misses for suspense, then
CHOMP –
the good life, of course.

I've been after the roadrunner for so long,
I can't tell if it's hunger, love,
or just plain stupidity.

Maybe that's what's so goddamn funny.

My life whittled down to a
riot of while pursuits and slim chances
to grab something that
I don't even understand.

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I mean, if I had his speed,
I'd get the hell away from here.
I'd be so gone,
even color couldn't catch me.
It's crazy. . .

I've died lots of times. LOTS!
blown up,
bowled over by boulders,
run over by trucks.

Somedays when I'm a thousand feet below the ledge
and a thousand more from impact,
I stop and look up at that
pebble-headed feather duster
and touch my chin. . . .

Who keeps bringing me back?

How can I keep hitting the ground and
getting up with nothing but
another perfect scheme.
It's got to end somewhere doesn't it?

There's got to be some way to . . . .
I don't even want to be a coyote anymore.

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carnivirest sharpest toothiest.

It's not me.

It's like my appetite doesn't belong in my belly.
Like I'm hungry because
someone else wants to eat.

Like I'm stuck in this story
no matter how bad I want to get out.
and me trying to get out of the story
IS the story.

Of course, I think my life means something
and of course, it does.

Otherwise, I'd be running around all the time . . .
and there would be no . . .
it would seem like my life had been . . .
I mean, who hasn't wondered, right?

But if this is not my life,
then what am I doing and
who should I ask?

Honestly,
if you can just stand still for a minute,

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you start to see the whole show.
I mean, it's all perspective.

If you can step out of the action
long enough to catch your breath,
you become your own audience.

And, of course, there you are,
a scrawny animal
starving in the middle of a desert
squeezing your knife and fork.

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